

KEY TOPIC 1: THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC

Student Workbook

Name:

Class:

Progress & Assessment Tracker

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Do Now	Level	Teacher Comment
KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919	Do Now: / 4		
KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923	Do Now: / 5		
KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929	Do Now: / 5		
KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929	Do Now: / 5		
Final Unit Grade:			

KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of the catastrophic social, economic, and political situation in Germany at the end of the First World War.
- ☐ Analyse the chronological sequence of events that led to the abdication of Kaiser Wilhelm II, the signing of the Armistice, and the birth of the Republic.
- ☐ Evaluate the democratic strengths and structural weaknesses of the new Weimar Constitution, judging the extent to which it left the Republic vulnerable to instability.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. List the ways in which a major conflict like the First World War might weaken a country's government and economy.

2. Define: What is an 'autocracy', and who held this absolute power in Germany before 1918?

3. Recall: What were the typical beliefs and policies of extreme left-wing and right-wing political groups in the early 20th century?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about what you already know regarding Germany's defeat in the First World War.

Vocabulary Check

Style: Contextual Cloze

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Reichstag | Reichsrat | Armistice | Constitution | Dolchstoßlegende | November Criminals | Proportional Representation (PR) | Coalition Government | Article 48

By the autumn of 1918, Germany was physically, financially, and psychologically broken. The First World War had drained the nation's resources. Financially, the German government's debt had tripled from 50 billion marks in 1914 to 150 billion marks in 1918. Humanly, the cost was staggering: 2 million German soldiers had been killed and over 4 million wounded (roughly 55% of all German troops became casualties).

Crucially, the home front was collapsing. The British naval blockade had prevented food and supplies from reaching Germany, resulting in the starvation of approximately 750,000 civilians. Disillusionment quickly turned to anger. The German public had been fed government

propaganda promising imminent victory; when the reality of unavoidable defeat set in, society began to implode. Strikes rippled across the country, and the people turned their fury on their autocratic ruler, **Kaiser Wilhelm II**.

The breaking point occurred in late October 1918. The German naval command ordered a final, suicidal attack on the British Royal Navy. The sailors at the Kiel naval base refused to follow orders, triggering a widespread mutiny. This defiance spread like wildfire. Across Germany, workers and soldiers began setting up their own unofficial councils, seizing control of local governments in major cities.

Realising that the army would no longer fight for him, and informed by the Allies that they would not negotiate peace with a military autocrat, **Kaiser Wilhelm II** bowed to the inevitable. On 9 November 1918, he abdicated and fled to exile in Holland.

With the Kaiser gone, Berlin descended into chaos. To prevent a communist takeover by the radical Spartacists, **Philipp Scheidemann**, a leading member of the **Social Democratic Party (SPD)**, rushed to a balcony of the Reichstag and proclaimed Germany a democratic republic.

The following day, [Key Individual: Friedrich Ebert] (SPD) became Chancellor of a temporary government called the Council of People's Representatives. His most pressing task was ending the war. On 11 November 1918, his representative, [Key Individual: Matthias Erzberger], signed the Armistice. While this ended the bloodshed, it was deeply unpopular. Because the German army had not been invaded and was still stationed in France, many Germans felt betrayed. A toxic myth was born: the *Dolchstoßlegende*. The democratic politicians who signed the Armistice were branded the 'November Criminals'. From day one, the new Republic was associated with surrender and national shame.

In January 1919, Germany held its first democratic elections. Because Berlin was still engulfed in violent political riots, the newly elected politicians met in the peaceful town of Weimar to draft the rules for how the country should be governed.

The **Weimar Constitution** established a clear chain of power:

- **The President:** The Head of State, elected every 7 years by the people. He played no part in day-to-day politics but commanded the army and chose the Chancellor.
- **The Chancellor:** The Head of Government, who ran the country day-to-day. He needed the support of a majority of politicians in the **Reichstag** to pass laws.
- **The Electorate:** All men and women over the age of 20 had the right to vote.
- **Local Power:** The 18 local regions (*Länder*) kept their own local parliaments (and were represented nationally in the *Reichsrat*).

On paper, the Weimar Constitution was one of the most progressive and democratic documents in the world. However, to a historian, it is clear that this document contained fatal structural flaws that would leave the Republic vulnerable to total collapse.

Strengths (Highly Democratic)	Weaknesses (Fatal Flaws)
Universal Suffrage: It was incredibly forward-thinking. Women received the vote on the same terms as men, and the voting age was reduced from 25 to 21 (and later 20), making it more democratic than Britain at the time.	Proportional Representation (PR): Because every 60,000 votes guaranteed one seat, tiny extremist parties easily gained a voice in the Reichstag.
Checks and Balances: No single person or group could hold too much power. The President, Chancellor, and Reichstag all kept each other in check.	Coalition Governments: PR made it mathematically almost impossible for one party to win a majority. Parties had to join together to form weak 'coalitions' that constantly argued and frequently collapsed during crises.
Local Power: The 18 <i>Länder</i> (local regions) retained control over key local services like the police, courts, and education, ensuring power was not heavily centralised in Berlin.	Article 48: The 'suicide clause'. In an emergency, the President could suspend the Constitution and pass laws by decree, bypassing the Reichstag entirely. It provided a legal backdoor to dictatorship.
Rights of the Individual: Freedom of speech, religion, and the press were legally guaranteed for all German citizens.	Undemocratic Foundations: The Republic was built on compromise and imposed upon a military, judiciary, and civil service that largely despised democracy and longed for the Kaiser.

Active Tasks

Constrained Summary

Q1. Summarize Philipp Scheidemann's declaration in Source A in exactly 10 words. You are NOT allowed to use the words 'Monarchy' or 'Republic'.

Historian's Judgement

Q2. How useful is Source B for an enquiry into the reasons for Germany's defeat in 1918? Evaluate the source using its provenance (motive) and your own contextual knowledge.

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q3. Complete these three sentences with historically accurate details: 1) Proportional Representation was highly democratic, BUT... 2) Philipp Scheidemann rushed to declare a Republic BECAUSE... 3) The army felt betrayed by the Armistice, SO...

Causal Linkage

Q4. Write a short paragraph explaining exactly how the British Naval Blockade eventually led to the Abdication of the Kaiser. You must explain the chain reaction of events (the 'domino effect') that connects them.

Transforming Information

Q5. Imagine you are an advisor to President Ebert in 1919. Write a short, urgent memo to him explaining which specific weakness of the new Constitution (Article 48, Proportional Representation, or Coalitions) poses the greatest threat to the Republic, and why.

Vocabulary in Context

Q6. Write a 4-sentence summary of the birth of the Weimar Republic. You must use all five of these keywords correctly: Autocracy, Dolchstoßlegende, November Criminals, Armistice, Reichstag.

The 'Diamond Ranking' Challenge

Q7. You have been given four reasons why the Weimar Republic was highly unstable in 1919:

1. The legacy of the First World War
2. The 'Stab-in-the-back' myth
3. Proportional Representation
4. Article 48

Rank these four causes in order of importance. Write a persuasive, open-ended paragraph justifying your #1 choice over your #2 choice.

Level 9 Challenge: *In your paragraph, use complex causal reasoning to explicitly explain how your #1 cause directly triggered or worsened your #2 cause.*

Q8. GCSE Exam Practice

Explain why the Weimar Republic was highly unstable in 1919 (12 marks).

You may use the following in your answer:

- The 'Stab-in-the-back' myth
- Proportional Representation

You must also use information of your own.

Documentary / General Notes

Title / Topic: _____

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of the Treaty of Versailles and explain why it made the Republic instantly unpopular.
- ☐ Analyse the political challenges from the extreme Left (the Spartacist Uprising) and the extreme Right (the Kapp Putsch), evaluating why the Republic struggled to maintain authority.
- ☐ Evaluate the causes and devastating social and economic consequences of the 1923 Ruhr crisis and hyperinflation, identifying the 'winners' and 'losers' of the economic collapse.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 5

Vocabulary Check

Style: Vocabulary Mapping

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Diktat | Reparations | Spartacist League | Freikorps | Putsch | Passive Resistance | Hyperinflation

Your Sentence:

The Weimar Republic was born into defeat, but the terms of the peace treaty nearly destroyed it entirely. When the German delegation travelled to the Palace of Versailles in France, they expected a fair treaty based on US President Woodrow Wilson's 'Fourteen Points'. Instead, they were barred from negotiating and forced to sign a **Diktat** on **28 June 1919**.

For a historian, the terms can be broken down into four devastating categories:

- **Blame:** Article 231 (The War Guilt Clause) forced Germany to accept full and total blame for starting the war. This was the psychological blow that hurt the most.
- **Reparations:** Because they accepted the blame, Germany had to pay for all civilian damage. In 1921, this was fixed at a crippling £6.6 billion (132 billion gold marks).
- **Armed Forces:** The proud German military was gutted. The army was limited to 100,000 volunteers (no conscription). They were forbidden from having submarines, tanks, or an air force. The Rhineland (bordering France) was demilitarised.
- **Territory:** Germany lost 13% of its European territory (including the industrial powerhouse of Upper Silesia) and 100% of its overseas colonies.

The public reaction was pure outrage. The democratic politicians who signed it were forever tainted as the 'November Criminals', and right-wing nationalists used the Treaty to fuel their hatred of the Republic.

Before the Treaty was even signed, the Republic faced a fight for its life. The **Spartacist League**, an extreme left-wing communist group led by Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht, wanted to trigger a Russian-style workers' revolution.

On 6 January 1919, 100,000 communists took to the streets of Berlin, seizing control of key government buildings and telegraph offices. Chancellor Ebert's problem was that the regular army (the *Reichswehr*) was too weak to put down the revolt. In a desperate move, he deployed the **Freikorps**—heavily armed, right-wing ex-soldiers who despised communism. The Freikorps crushed the uprising with ruthless violence. Luxemburg and Liebknecht were arrested, beaten, and murdered. While the Republic survived, Ebert's reliance on right-wing thugs alienated the working class and proved that the democratic government could not maintain order on its own.

By early 1920, the government tried to disband several Freikorps units to comply with the 100,000-man army limit dictated by Versailles. Outraged, 5,000 Freikorps marched on Berlin in March 1920, led by a right-wing nationalist named **Wolfgang Kapp**. They intended to overthrow the Republic and bring back the Kaiser.

Ebert ordered the regular army to fire on the rebels, but the head of the army refused, stating: "*Reichswehr does not fire on Reichswehr*". The army was perfectly happy to shoot communists in 1919, but they would not shoot their right-wing brothers. Ebert and the government were forced to flee the capital. Kapp declared a new government.

However, Kapp was defeated not by the military, but by the people. Ebert called on the workers of Berlin to launch a **General Strike**. Millions of workers downed tools. Gas, electricity, water, and transport ground to a halt. Realising he could not rule a paralysed country, Kapp fled to Sweden. The Republic survived again, but the key takeaway is clear: the Weimar government had virtually zero control over its own military.

Right-Wing Terrorism and Political Assassinations

The Kapp Putsch was not an isolated incident; it was part of a wider campaign of relentless right-wing terrorism. Between 1919 and 1922, there were 376 political assassinations in Germany, predominantly carried out by right-wing extremists targeting democratic politicians. The most high-profile victims included **Matthias Erzberger** (the politician who signed the Armistice), who was gunned down in 1921, and **Walther Rathenau** (the Weimar Foreign Minister), who was assassinated in 1922. This constant wave of murder proved to the German people that the Republic was fundamentally unstable and struggling to protect its own leaders.

By late 1922, Germany's economy was failing, and they failed to send their scheduled reparations payment to France. The French believed the Germans were lying. In **January 1923**, French and Belgian troops invaded the **Ruhr**, Germany's most vital industrial region, to seize coal, steel, and manufactured goods as payment.

The German government could not fight back militarily. Instead, they ordered the workers of the Ruhr to carry out **Passive Resistance**—to go on strike and refuse to produce anything for the French. The French responded brutally, bringing in their own workers, arresting those who resisted, and shooting over 100 Germans.

Passive resistance created an apocalyptic economic crisis. The government was suddenly deprived of the wealth generated by the Ruhr, yet it still had to pay the wages of the striking workers. The government's solution was disastrous: they simply printed more paper money.

Printing unbacked money completely destroyed its value, triggering **Hyperinflation**. Prices spiralled out of control daily, then hourly. A loaf of bread that cost 0.6 marks in 1918 cost 201 billion marks by November 1923. Workers had to be paid twice a day and carried their wages in wheelbarrows before prices went up again.

The Winners and Losers of Hyperinflation:

- **The Losers:** The middle classes were devastated. Anyone with savings in the bank, fixed pensions, or fixed incomes saw their life's wealth wiped out overnight.
- **The Winners:** Anyone with loans or mortgages could pay off their debts with worthless paper money. Farmers benefited because the food they produced could be sold at highly inflated prices. Foreigners in Germany with foreign currency (like the US Dollar) could suddenly afford to buy businesses and property for a fraction of their real value.

By late 1923, the Republic was humiliated, bankrupt, and seemingly on the brink of total collapse.

The 'Inflation King' and the Munich Putsch

While hyperinflation destroyed the middle classes, a few wealthy industrialists thrived. Figures like **Hugo Stinnes**—who became known as the 'Inflation King'—used worthless paper money to buy up bankrupt businesses and cheap industrial land, vastly expanding his empire. However, the sheer chaos of 1923 had one final political consequence. In November 1923, believing the Republic was on the verge of total collapse, a relatively unknown right-wing extremist named **Adolf Hitler** and his Nazi Party attempted to seize power in Bavaria in an event known as the **Munich Putsch**.

Documentary / General Notes

Title / Topic: _____

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of Stresemann's economic strategies, including the Rentenmark, the Dawes Plan, and the Young Plan.
- ☐ Analyse Stresemann's foreign policy achievements (the Locarno Pact, joining the League of Nations, the Kellogg-Briand Pact) and explain how they restored German pride.
- ☐ Evaluate the extent of German recovery by 1929, distinguishing between genuine political stability and superficial economic prosperity.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 5

Vocabulary Check

Style: Mini-Frayer Model

Complete the Frayer Model for the term: **Rentenmark**

Definition	Historical Example
Non-Example / Sketch	Your own sentence

In August 1923, at the height of the hyperinflation crisis, Gustav Stresemann became Chancellor. Though he was only Chancellor for 102 days before stepping down to become Foreign Minister (a post he held until his death in 1929), his impact was profound. Stresemann's ultimate goal was political stability. He believed that if he could fix the economy and restore Germany's respect on the world stage, the German people would unite behind moderate democratic parties and stop voting for extremists like the Communists and the Nazis.

Stresemann's first act was to call off the passive resistance in the Ruhr, getting Germans back to work. Next, he tackled hyperinflation. In November 1923, he destroyed the old, worthless currency and introduced a strictly controlled, temporary currency called the **Rentenmark**. Because Germany had no gold left, this currency was backed by the value of German industrial and agricultural land. People trusted it, and prices stabilised. In August 1924, control was handed over to the new Reichsbank, and a permanent currency, the **Reichsmark**, was introduced. The hyperinflation nightmare was officially over.

To get the economy moving again, Stresemann negotiated with the USA.

- **The Dawes Plan (1924):** The USA agreed to loan Germany 800 million gold marks. Reparation payments were temporarily lowered to an affordable level, and the French agreed to leave the Ruhr. American money flooded into Germany, building new factories, houses, and roads.

- **The Young Plan (1929):** Stresemann successfully negotiated a massive reduction in the total reparations bill, dropping it from £6.6 billion to £2 billion, and gained an extra 59 years to pay it off. This meant the government could lower taxes, giving ordinary Germans more money to spend. However, right-wing nationalists (including Adolf Hitler) were furious, arguing that paying *any* reparations was a betrayal of Germany.

Defeat in WWI had made Germany a global outcast. Stresemann used diplomacy—specifically a policy of fulfilling the Treaty of Versailles to build trust—to bring Germany back in from the cold.

- **The Locarno Pact (1925):** Unlike Versailles, this was a treaty Germany signed willingly as an equal partner. Germany agreed to accept its new western borders with France and Belgium, greatly reducing the threat of future war.
- **The League of Nations (1926):** Because of the Locarno Pact, Germany was trusted enough to be invited into the League of Nations. Crucially, they were given a seat on the executive Council, proving Germany was a 'great power' once again.
- **The Kellogg-Briand Pact (1928):** Germany was one of 65 nations to sign this pact, promising never to use war to achieve foreign policy goals.

Between 1924 and 1929, Germany experienced a 'Golden Age'. Politically, the Republic stabilised. Moderate parties dominated the Reichstag, and extreme parties lost support (the Nazis won just 12 seats in the 1928 election). However, a historian must recognize the fatal flaws hiding beneath the surface:

- **The Quicksand Economy:** Germany's entire recovery was dependent on short-term American loans. If the USA demanded their money back, the German economy would instantly collapse.
- **The Losers of the Golden Age:** Unemployment remained a persistent problem, never dropping below 1.3 million. Furthermore, farmers suffered from plummeting food prices, and the middle classes never got back the life savings they lost in 1923.

Shortly before his sudden death in October 1929, Stresemann himself issued a dark warning: *"The economic position is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is in fact dancing on a volcano."*

Documentary / General Notes

Title / Topic: _____

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate comprehensive knowledge of changes in the standard of living, including wages, housing, and unemployment insurance.
- ☐ Analyse the changing position of women in politics, work, and leisure, contrasting the reality of their lives with the image of the 'New Woman'.
- ☐ Evaluate the explosion of cultural changes in art, cinema, and architecture, judging why this provoked such fierce opposition from traditionalists and extremists.

Vocabulary Check

Style: Contextual Cloze

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Standard of Living | Unemployment Insurance Act (1927) | New Woman (Neue Frau)
| Article 109 | Avant-garde | New Objectivity (Neue Sachlichkeit) | Bauhaus

During the 'Golden Age', Germany's _____ improved for many, supported by progressive welfare reforms like the _____. Women were granted equal voting rights under _____, paving the way for the socially liberated, independent _____ who embraced modern fashion and work. Culturally, Berlin became a vibrant hub of _____ experimentation; artists embraced the realism of _____, while the revolutionary _____ movement transformed architecture and design with its sleek, functional aesthetic.

For many ordinary German workers, the years 1924–1929 saw a genuine improvement in their daily lives, largely funded by the Weimar government and American loans.

- **Wages and Work:** The length of the working week decreased, while 'real wages' (the actual purchasing power of a worker's pay) rose by 25% between 1925 and 1928.
- **Unemployment Insurance:** In 1927, the government passed the Unemployment Insurance Act. Workers and employers paid 3% of their wages into a national pot, which provided an average of 60 marks a week in benefits if a worker lost their job or fell ill.
- **Housing:** By 1923, Germany had a massive shortage of one million homes. In 1925, the government introduced a 15% rent tax to fund building associations. Between 1925 and 1929, over 100,000 new homes were built, drastically reducing homelessness.

Evaluation: While industrial workers benefited, the middle classes deeply resented seeing the working classes supported by the state, especially since the middle classes never recovered the savings they lost during the 1923 hyperinflation crisis.

The Hidden Economic Burden: War Veterans

Despite improvements in housing and wages for industrial workers, the Weimar government struggled under a massive welfare burden left over from the First World War. Under the **1920 Reich Pension Law**, the state was financially responsible for supporting approximately 2 million war widows, orphans, and disabled veterans. This caused deep resentment across society: the veterans and widows felt the government pensions were never enough to survive on, while taxpayers deeply resented the high taxes required to fund them.

The Weimar Constitution was incredibly progressive. Under **Article 109**, women were granted equal voting rights, the right to enter all professions, and equal pay in the civil service.

Area of Life	Progress (The 'Golden Age')	Lack of Progress (The Reality)
Politics	Women over 20 could vote. By 1926, there were 32 female deputies in the Reichstag—a higher proportion than in Britain or the USA.	Women rarely held the highest positions in political parties. No female cabinet ministers were ever appointed during the Weimar Republic.
Work	Women made huge gains in the civil service, teaching, social work, and retail. By 1933, there were 100,000 female teachers and 3,000 female doctors.	After WWI, men reclaimed the better-paid industrial jobs. Married women who worked were heavily criticised as 'double-earners' stealing jobs from unemployed men.
Leisure	The rise of the ' New Woman ': young, unmarried city women with financial independence. They cut their hair short, wore makeup, smoked, drank, and went out unchaperoned.	The 'New Woman' was mostly a media creation limited to big cities like Berlin. In rural, traditional areas, women were still expected to focus solely on being wives and mothers.

In the 1920s, Berlin challenged Paris as the cultural capital of Europe. This explosion of creativity was caused by three things: the end of strict pre-war censorship, the new Weimar Constitution guaranteeing freedom of speech, and economic recovery providing money to fund the arts.

- **Art:** Artists like **George Grosz** and **Otto Dix** pioneered the **New Objectivity** movement. Instead of painting beautiful landscapes, they painted the grim reality of Weimar life—disabled war veterans begging on the streets, corrupt politicians, and greedy businessmen.

- **Architecture: Walter Gropius** founded the **Bauhaus** school of design. They rejected the elaborate, decorative styles of the Kaiser's era. Instead, their slogan was "*Art and Technology - a new unity*," creating buildings and furniture using basic shapes, concrete, and steel.
- **Cinema and Nightlife:** The German film industry boomed. Director **Fritz Lang** produced *Metropolis* (1927), a groundbreaking science-fiction film, while **Marlene Dietrich** became a global superstar. Berlin's nightlife became famous for its vibrant, liberal cabaret clubs, jazz bands, and the open acceptance of homosexuality, which had been heavily suppressed under the Kaiser.

Literature and Theatre

The cultural revolution extended into writing and the stage. In 1929, **Erich Maria Remarque** published his highly successful anti-war novel, *All Quiet on the Western Front*, which challenged the right-wing myth that the First World War had been a glorious, heroic struggle. On the stage, directors pioneered **Zeittheater** and **Zeitoper** (theatre and opera of the time), which rejected traditional, historical plays in favour of realistic, highly political performances set in modern times.

To a top-level historian, the cultural 'Golden Age' was actually a source of severe weakness for the Republic because it deeply divided the nation.

- **Left-wing opposition:** The Communists believed government funding for the arts was an extravagant waste of money when ordinary working people were still struggling to buy food.
- **Right-wing opposition:** Nationalists, traditionalists, and the Nazi Party were horrified. They believed the new art, the cabaret clubs, and the 'New Woman' were immoral, un-German, and destroying traditional family values. This cultural divide handed the Nazis powerful propaganda weapons to attack the Republic.

Opposition from the Churches

The cultural explosion was not just attacked by political extremists; it faced fierce backlash from Germany's religious institutions. Both the **Catholic and Protestant Churches** actively campaigned against the 'New Woman', the cabaret clubs, and the open acceptance of homosexuality in Berlin. Church leaders believed that the Weimar Republic was leading Germany into a state of moral decline and aggressively urged their followers to reject this new, liberal culture in favour of traditional family values.

Documentary / General Notes

Title / Topic: _____

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:
